AUWA Instagram Strategy

Created: April 2026. Maintained as living document. Load when working on social media content, Instagram ads, or audience growth.

Strategy Summary

Instagram is AUWA's sole social platform until 5,000 followers. The audience (affluent, design-conscious, interested in Japanese culture, awareness, emotional intelligence) lives on Instagram, not TikTok. One strong account beats three scattered ones. Expand to TikTok reposts and YouTube depth content after 5K.

The Gift Ethos

Everything AUWA posts should feel like a gift, not a sale. Brands that behave like businesses plateau on Instagram; brands that behave like contributions compound. Every post should give the reader something. A new word, a moment of beauty, a piece of craft knowledge, a reflection they want to hold. The commercial messaging (teaser signups, product launches, store openings) appears rarely and quietly, as a natural consequence of trust already built, never as the driver of content.

Touchstones: Kinfolk, The Marginalian (Maria Popova), School of Life, Blackbird Spyplane. All gave freely for years before monetising lightly.

Tension to manage: "gift" is a feeling, not an identity. AUWA *is* a business. The posture is "a brand that behaves like a gift, and occasionally invites you to buy something we've made." Giving sets the default. Selling is an exception earned by giving first.

Restart Context (April 2026)

Rieko's earlier AUWA IG account reached roughly 700 followers through animated character posts. Those posts have been archived as the execution didn't match current ambition. The account now restarts fresh, but the 700 are an asset: they chose AUWA when it was quieter, smaller, less polished. Do not apologise for the archive or explain the hiatus. Welcome them by not referencing it. New visitors simply arrive alongside them.

Animated character content was the original growth hook and remains AUWA's single most uncopyable asset. In the new mix, it should carry more than a quarter of the grid weight (see Recommended Mix below).

Image & Video Specs (2025-2026 Standards)

Reels (Primary Growth Format)

- **Dimensions:** 1080 x 1920px (9:16 vertical)
- **Safe zone:** Keep text/key visuals within centre 1080 x 1420px — top ~200px and bottom ~250px obscured by UI overlays
- **Length:** 30-60 seconds is the sweet spot. 15-30 seconds for maximum discovery/reach. Up to 3 minutes supported but only if retention is high
- **Format:** MP4, H.264, 30fps minimum
- **Cover photo:** Displays 1080 x 1920 in Reels tab, crops to 1080 x 1350 in feed grid — design covers with this dual crop in mind

Stories

- **Dimensions:** 1080 x 1920px (9:16)
- **Duration:** Up to 60 seconds per slide
- **Engagement:** 5-7 slides per sequence performs well; drop-off accelerates after slide 7
- **Interactive stickers** (polls, quizzes, sliders, questions) are heavily weighted by the algorithm

Feed Posts — Single Image

- **Recommended:** 1080 x 1350px (4:5 portrait) — maximum screen real estate in feed
- **Square:** 1080 x 1080 (1:1) still works but less impactful
- **Landscape:** 1080 x 566 (1.91:1) — avoid; wastes screen space

Feed Posts — Carousel

- **Dimensions:** 1080 x 1350px (4:5) recommended
- **Up to 20 slides** (increased from 10 in mid-2024)
- **All slides same aspect ratio**
- **Key insight:** Carousels are re-served to users who didn't engage first time (Instagram shows slide 2+ on second impression). Highest-reach static format.

Profile Photo

- Displays 110 x 110px mobile, 180 x 180px desktop
- Upload at 500 x 500px minimum (circular crop)

Algorithm Priorities (2025-2026)

1. **Sends/shares via DM** — the #1 ranking signal. Content people send to friends gets dramatically more reach
2. **Watch-through rate on Reels** — watched to completion or replayed = major boost
3. **Original content prioritised** — algorithm deprioritises content with watermarks from other platforms
4. **Carousels now rival Reels** for reach — a major shift from 2023
5. **Caption text is indexed** for Instagram search — write captions with natural keywords (emotional intelligence, Japanese philosophy, mindfulness etc.)

Content Pillars (4 Themes)

Every post fits one pillar. Rotate through the week for variety within coherence.

1. Kokoro Reveal (Inspire / Share)

AUWA illustrations paired with poetic reflections. Emotional insight that stops the scroll. The brand's signature content.

- **Format:** Single stunning image, short atmospheric Reel
- **Purpose:** Brand building, shareability (DM sends)

- **Examples:** AUWA character in emotional state + reflection text, shareable kokoro cards

2. Japanese Wisdom (Educate / Discover)

Yamato emotional concepts, micro-season philosophy, Japanese ideas (mono no aware, wabi-sabi, ma, ikigai). The intellectual depth that differentiates.

- **Format:** Carousels (5-7 slides teaching), short Reels with text overlay
- **Purpose:** Authority, discoverability, attract the curious
- **Examples:** "5 ancient Japanese words for emotions you've never heard of," "The word for the feeling when autumn arrives"

3. Behind the Kokoro (Connect / Humanise)

Rieko's illustration process, creative decisions, the journey of building AUWA. The human story.

- **Format:** Stories, Reels (time-lapses, process videos), casual carousels
- **Purpose:** Creator connection, authenticity, community
- **Examples:** Rieko drawing AUWA, illustration before/after, studio moments, Japan trip BTS

4. Seasonal Living (Lifestyle / Aspire)

Atmospheric content tied to the rhythm of the year. Not micro-season taxonomy, but the feeling of seasonal change. Morning light, rain on leaves, the shift from spring to summer. Also bridges awareness to everyday experience — the philosophical applied to the personal.

- **Format:** Atmospheric Reels, photo carousels, single striking images, text-based carousels, quote graphics
- **Purpose:** Mood, aspiration, discoverability, the life AUWA represents
- **Examples:** Japan travel photography, temple visits, seasonal nature, onsen, silent walks, "Why you feel restless at the change of seasons"

Weekly Cadence (Sustainable Three-Post Rhythm)

Three posts per week, sustainable indefinitely. Over-posting burns out the creator and confuses the algorithm. Consistency beats volume. A steady three-post rhythm for 52 weeks outperforms five posts a week for three months.

- **Mid-week Reel** (character animation) — Tuesday or Wednesday. The growth engine. Brings new followers in.
- **Weekend Slideshow** (article digest, see Editorial Slideshow Format below) — Friday or Saturday. Deepens the audience already there. Drives traffic to auwa.life.
- **Sunday post** (micro-season photograph + kanji, or atmospheric Seasonal Living image) — Sunday evening. The quiet close to the week.

Stories (daily, 1-3 slides)

Rotate across pillars. Process snippets, studio moments, reactions to the week. Stories are looser than the grid. Use interactive stickers at least twice/week (polls, sliders, question boxes).

Recommended Mix (weighted by pillar, not format)

- **35%** Kokoro Reveal — the character, the uncopyable asset, the growth driver
- **25%** Editorial Slideshows — journal articles digested for the grid
- **20%** Seasonal Living — atmospheric photography, micro-season rhythm, moody
- **10%** Japanese Wisdom — carousel explainers, save-worthy
- **10%** Behind the Kokoro — studio moments, process, humanising

Format mix that results from the weighted pillars: roughly 40% Reels, 40% Slideshows/Carousels, 20% single images. Reels drive reach and new followers; slideshows drive saves, shares, and return visits.

Editorial Slideshow Format

For each Journal article, a companion Instagram carousel turns editorial writing into swipeable grid content. The format honours the Gift Ethos: readers learn something or hold something beautiful, rather than being sold to.

Template (5 slides):

1. **Hero** — the article's hero image, no text overlay (or a single floating title in small caps)
2. **Pull quote A** — short phrase, large serif, on white or colour wash. Make the viewer pause.
3. **Pull quote B** — different typography from A. Medium-length excerpt overlaid on a photo detail or colour field.
4. **Pull quote C** — third and final quote. Shortest of the three. Returns emotional weight.

5. **Close** — a final quiet image with "auwa.life/journal" beneath it. No loud CTA. "Continue reading at auwa.life" is fine if a line is needed.

Key principles:

- The three pull quotes must feel typographically distinct from each other. Identical layouts = scrolled past.
- Each article generates one slideshow. With a weekly cadence, that's ~50 slideshows per year — a meaningful editorial pipeline.
- Never use the format to sell anything. If a product teaser is needed, make that a separate post.

Content Ideas (Vault + Ongoing)

Ready to deploy now (existing vault)

- Japan photography (15+ years of trips)
- Rieko's illustrations and AUWA animations
- Fin DAC AUWA stencil session
- Craftsman photography from Monolise research trips
- AUWA story scenes (10+ polished scenes)
- Rieko drawing process time-lapses

Ongoing production

- AUWA character animations (Runway, After Effects)
- Craft ASMR clips (artisan hands, making processes)
- Japan travel teases (temples, paths, seasonal moments)
- Stories/polls ("Which emotion resonates today?")
- Collaborations (Fin DAC collab post, Japanese culture accounts)
- EQ tips and frameworks (carousel series)
- Kokoro quotes (text over illustration)
- App demos and shareable card reveals (post-launch)
- Store unboxing and craftsman spotlights (post-store launch)
- Artisan spotlights (craftsman meets, workshop visits)
- Silent walks (ambient video, no voiceover)
- Seasonal rituals and wellness content

Growth Plan: 700 → 5,000 Followers

Phase 1: Relaunch (Weeks 1-4)

First post (Week 1, Monday): The AUWA face video from the website hero. Post as a **Reel** (not a Story, not a feed post). A Reel is the only format that plays on the Reels tab for non-follower discovery, autoposts to the grid, and gets re-served to users across sessions. Stories disappear in 24 hours and don't reach new audiences; single-image feed posts have a fraction of Reel reach.

Caption (three sentences, no em dashes):

"Hello. Kokoro (心) is the Japanese word for heart, mind and spirit held as one. The quality you sense in a handmade knife, in a season you almost missed, in your own feelings when you stop long enough to notice. auwa.life."

Don't explain the archive or the hiatus. No "we're back," no "exciting things coming." Just presence.

Hashtags (in caption, not first comment):

`#AUWA #kokoro #japanesephilosophy #slowliving #japaneseaesthetic`

Five hashtags: one branded, one niche, two mid-range, one broad. Refine over the first month based on which reach the right audience.

Share to Story with a link sticker, immediately after posting. Stories support link stickers (since 2021). Tap "Add yours" or the link sticker, point it to auwa.life, publish. This gives the Reel dual life: Reel drives reach and grid visibility, Story drives direct traffic to the site.

If Instagram's native "Add link" feature on Reels is available to the account (available to many business accounts), add auwa.life there too. The Reel caption should also say "link in bio" for anyone who sees it via the Reels tab.

Pin the post to the top of the grid and leave it there for at least two weeks, so every new profile visitor lands on it before anything else.

Do not post anything else on Day 1. Let it breathe. The next post (character Reel or editorial slideshow) arrives mid-week per the weekly cadence above.

The 700 existing followers get a gentle re-anchor. New visitors get a self-contained introduction. The video carries the emotional weight.

Weeks 1-4:

- Pin 3 best posts to top of grid (first face-video post, the first character Reel, the first editorial slideshow)
- Settle into the three-post weekly cadence (Reel, slideshow, Sunday post) from Week 2
- Daily Stories (1-3 slides, stickers, behind-scenes glimpses)
- Engage genuinely on 10-15 relevant accounts daily (Japanese art, calligraphy, seasonal living, emotional wellness, design culture)
- Bio: "AUWA | Japanese Awareness Practice" — clear value prop, link to auwa.life
- Highlights: Universe, Kokoro, Seasons, Process (4-6 with custom covers matching brand aesthetic)

Phase 2: Paid Acceleration (Weeks 5-10)

- Begin Instagram ads: £15-25/day on best-performing organic Reels
- Campaign split: 60% Engagement/Awareness (follower growth), 30% Traffic (email capture to teaser pages), 10% Retargeting
- Targeting: Japanese culture, emotional intelligence, mindfulness, illustration art, wellness, Studio Ghibli, wabi-sabi
- A/B test 2-3 ad variations per campaign, run 5-7 days before optimising
- DM automation (ManyChat): "Comment KOKORO to get early access" → auto-DM with waitlist link

Phase 3: Collaboration + Launch (Weeks 8-12)

- Fin DAC collab post (his stencil of AUWA, co-authored via Instagram native collab feature)
- Instagram giveaway tied to first figure drop ("Tag a friend for a chance to win the first AUWA figure")
- App soft launch content: shareable kokoro cards, light shower video, user testimonials
- Reach out to 5-10 complementary accounts (5K-50K followers) for collab posts

Expected Results

- £2,000 paid spend → 1,500-3,000 new quality followers + 300-800 email signups
- Organic growth (content + collabs) → additional 1,000-2,000 followers

- Target: 3,000-5,000 total followers by Month 3-4

Paid Advertising (£2,000 Year 1 Budget)

- **Budget pacing:** £15-25/day over 2-3 months (not £50/day for 1 month — algorithm needs time to optimise)
- **Creative:** repurpose best-performing organic content as ads. Native-feeling outperforms polished "ad-looking" creative
- **Objectives:** Use "Engagement" or "Awareness" for follower growth (NOT the "Followers" objective — attracts low-quality). Use "Traffic" or "Leads" for email capture
- **Lead forms:** Instagram's native Lead Form ad format collects emails within the app (no landing page friction)
- **Retargeting:** Small budget on people who visited teaser pages but didn't sign up
- **Budget split:** £1,200 Reel ads (growth/awareness), £500 conversion ads (email capture), £300 retargeting

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Profile Setup

- **Name field:** "AUWA | Japanese Awareness Practice" (searchable, keyword-rich)
- **Bio:** Lead with what it IS. "Japanese philosophical awareness applied to modern life. Reveal your kokoro. auwa.life launching 2026." Minimal emoji (1-2 max for premium feel)
- **Category:** Health/Beauty or Art
- **Profile photo:** AUWA wordmark or character icon at 500x500px minimum
- **Link:** Use Instagram's native 5-link feature (waitlist, auwa.life/journal, specific content piece). No third-party link tools needed
- **Highlights (4-6):** Universe, Kokoro, Seasons, Process, Press — custom covers in brand colours

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Best Posting Times (UK)

- **Weekdays:** 7:00-8:30 AM (morning scroll), 12:00-1:00 PM (lunch), 7:00-9:00 PM (evening)

- **Sunday:** 10:00 AM-12:00 PM (lifestyle/wellness performs well)
- **Japan overlap:** 7-8 AM UK = 3-4 PM Japan (if dual-audience matters, morning posts hit both)
- Refine with Instagram Insights once audience data accumulates

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Hashtag Strategy

3-5 highly relevant hashtags per post (not 20-30 generic ones):

- 1-2 broad (500K-5M posts): #emotionalintelligence, #japanesephilosophy
- 2-3 mid-range (50K-500K): #japaneseart, #japanesecraft, #awarenessjournal
- 1-2 niche/branded: #AUWA, #kokoromirror, #revealyourkokoro
- Place in caption (not first comment). Vary between posts.
- Use alt text on images with natural keyword descriptions for additional discovery.

Key Metrics to Track

- **Follower growth rate** (weekly)
- **Reach per post** (especially non-follower reach)
- **Shares/sends** (the #1 algorithm signal)
- **Saves** (indicates high-value content)
- **Email signups from Instagram** (teaser page conversions)
- **Engagement rate** (likes + comments + saves + shares / reach)
- **Best-performing content type** (Reel vs carousel vs single)

Photography & Image Workflow

Tom's credentials: Published photographer. Japan photography has 17M+ views on Unsplash and has been used by Condé Nast Traveler, Vogue, WEF, Travel + Leisure, TimeOut, and Culture Trip. 15+ years of Japan photography provides a deep content vault.

Content production pipeline:

- Japan travel catalogue (temples, seasonal landscapes, street scenes, food culture) → Seasonal Living pillar
- Craftsman photography from Monolise research trips → Behind the Kokoro / Store spotlights
- Rieko's illustration process captures → Behind the Kokoro pillar
- AI-assisted image standardisation for store products (Remove.bg, Claude Vision → consistent white backgrounds)
- MidJourney + Rieko refinement for AUWA character content → Kokoro Reveal pillar

Image editing: Lightroom for photography. Remove.bg or Claude Vision for product background removal. Figma for card layouts, carousel templates, and Story templates. Canva as fallback for quick social graphics.

Expansion (Post-5K)

- **TikTok:** Repurpose best-performing Instagram Reels. Same content, different platform. Low effort.
- **YouTube:** Original depth content. Craftsman making videos (30-45 min ASMR), Japan travel, philosophy deep-dives, interviews. Bi-weekly uploads. This is the long-term authority-building channel.
- **Podcast appearances:** Pitch wellness, Japan culture, design, and EQ podcasts after 5K as social proof.